Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Theodore Roethke's "Root Cellar"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of this poem include

alliteration,
assonance,
contrast,
diction,
imagery (sensual),
metaphor,
optimism,
personification,
sigmatism,
simile sympathy/empathy,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant is asked to consider the persona's sensitivity to nature and his awareness of the "agony of birth" as they give meaning to Roethke's "Root Cellar." The careful observer will note the optimism in the opening declaration, "Nothing would sleep" (living must be active); he or she might also note the profundity of the last two lines in which the optimism, relative to the imagery that pervades the description of the cellar, exudes from the darkness and the dankness: "Nothing would give up life: / Even the dirt kept breathing [. . .]."

The imagery is visual and olfactory; additionally, the word choices whisper primal activity. The young writer might notice Roethke's use of sound devices to accentuate the activity, which, while certainly visual, must be imagined (as well as heard and smelled) because the cellar is dark.

The writer who has been working with Roethke's poetry might focus on the bracketing "Nothing woulds," found in line 1 and lines 10-11, and address the poet's sensitivity to nature, which is framed by implicit personification through sympathetic comparison (sleeping and breathing): there is something in all that lives, especially in its coming to life, that is immediately observable in nature. The natural world has a soul that resonates in our observing it in its "small breaths."